

FESTIVALS



ALL OVER THE WORLD, people set aside special days each year to enjoy themselves at festivals. These public celebrations are held for many reasons: they may be linked to a community's religious beliefs, mark the changing seasons, or honour important events in a country's history.

Day of the Dead

On 1 November, Mexicans celebrate the Day of the Dead, to honour people who have died. Families have picnics by the graves of their relatives, decorate the streets with flowers and carved skeletons, and eat sweets shaped like skulls and coffins.

Papier-mâché skeleton



Calendar festivals

The majority of festivals are held at the same time each year. Many religions have adapted the celebrations of early peoples to their own ends: the Christian Christmas and the Hindu Diwali are held around the same time as ancient feasts marking the onset of winter.

Harvest festivals

Ancient peoples thought that thanking the gods would ensure a good crop the next year, and people still celebrate festivals based on this idea. There are many festivals in Africa and Papua New Guinea that celebrate the yam crop, and the Oktoberfest beer festival in Germany began as thanks for the crop of hops.



Radishes

On Christmas Eve, townspeople in Oaxaca, Mexico, celebrate their radish crop by carving large, recently harvested radishes into elaborate shapes, which they use to decorate market stalls and restaurants. Food is served on chipped plates, which are saved for the occasion and smashed at the end of the night.

Corn

In England, people often used the last of the year's corn to make a figure called a corn dolly. The dolly kept the corn spirit alive through the winter, ensuring another good harvest the next year.

Traditional English corn dolly



Carnivals

Originally, carnivals were pagan festivals to celebrate the rebirth of nature in spring. Later, they became associated with the Roman Catholic festival of Lent. The start and duration of the carnival season varies from country to country.

Carnival in Venice

This famous Italian carnival first began in the 11th century. Traditionally, many revellers wear masks. They originally did this to hide their faces while they behaved outrageously.



Float pulled by tractor



Mardi Gras float

Caribbean carnival

Carnival in the Caribbean combines African and European traditions; dance, costume, and music are important parts of African religious beliefs.

Mardi Gras

In many Roman Catholic countries, carnival is by tradition a last chance for merry-making before the start of Lent, the weeks of fasting that come before Easter. Thousands of people enjoy the week-long Mardi Gras carnival in New Orleans, USA, which is named after the French for "Fat Tuesday". This refers to Shrove Tuesday, the day before Lent begins, when all the fats in the home must be used up. Another spectacular Mardi Gras carnival is held in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil.



Modern festivals

Most festivals set up today mark non-religious events. The Olympics celebrate excellence in sports; the Edinburgh festival in the UK promotes the performing arts.



Mime artist, Edinburgh Festival

Roskilde

Thousands of fans attend this summer rock music festival in Denmark.

Political festivals

Significant political dates are often the cause for regular celebration. Festivals mark the anniversary of a nation's independence or a great leader's birthday: in the USA, there is a holiday on George Washington's birthday.



May Day

Once a springtime fertility festival, May 1 is a now a public holiday to honour workers. In Russia, May Day is marked with trades union parades.

Streamers are hung from a pole.



Children's Day

To mark Children's Day (5 May) in Japan, streamers in the shape of carp are hung out. The strong, energetic fish is seen as a good role model for young children.

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